Pakistani PM Nawaz Sharif into confidence before requesting India to give the embattled Afghan president political asylum.[6] It had taken India's PM Narasimha Rao less than an hour to communicate that India would host Najibullah as state guest in New Delhi. On that fateful morning, however, driving with his armed bodyguard and a team of UN officers, Najibullah's convoy was refused entry into the Kabul airport. The password he used throughout the journey from home to the airport did not work at the penultimate checkpoint.[7] The airport was under the control of Abdul Rashid Dostum, an Afghan of Uzbek heritage, who led a local militia against the Mujahideen in the northern province of Jowzjan, and had been receiving political, financial, and military patronage from Najibullah. In a total 'wild card', as the then Indian ambassador to Kabul Vijay K. Nambiar terms it, Dostum turned hostile towards his patron, and shutdown the airport for the next 24 hours.[8]

On the airport's runway stood a plane, and in the plane awaited Sevan. Dostum's men had decided not to storm the plane, and Sevan had decided not to disembark. After a furious exchange of abuses with and impotent threats to Dostum's men, Najibullah turned his convoy around. But he would not return home. He feared that the people who sabotaged his escape would not let him live. His minister of state security, General Ghulam Faruq Yaqubi, was found dead in his house. While some allege that he committed suicide, Nambiar, who was in touch with Najibullah and his UN handlers, does not rule out assassination.[9] Either way, Najibullah was escorted to the UN compound instead of the presidential palace. Not just Dostum, most of his party men had also abandoned Najibullah. Foreign Minister Abdul Wakil and army chief General Mohammad Nabi Azimi, keen on their own political and physical survival, wanted to offer Najibullah as a prisoner to the advancing Mujahideen forces.[10] They had rushed to the airport on getting news of Najibullah's escape attempt, and asked Sevan to disembark the plane to avoid further embarrassment and potential violence (they wanted Sevan alive and safe given his UN connection). Wakil, accompanied by many other members of the Watan party, castigated Sevan for trying to get Najibullah out of Afghanistan secretly. In his next step, an angry Wakil sent out a national broadcast via Radio Kabul stating that 'Najibullah tried to escape but had been stopped by the armed forces ... He must be held to answer certain